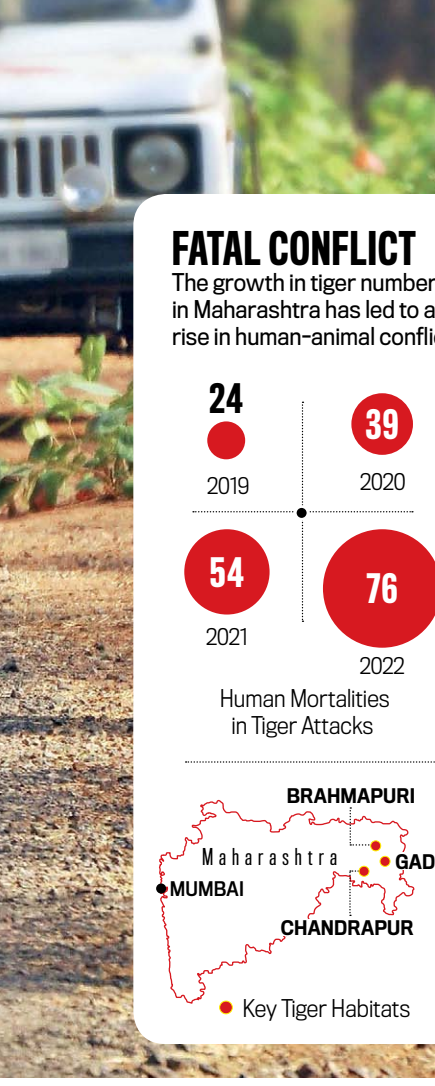


FATAL CONFLICT

The growth in tiger numbers in Maharashtra has led to a rise in human-animal conflict



INDIA PICTURE

for the first such relocation of tigers. Accordingly, five female tigers from the Bramhapuri forest division in Chandrapur will be shifted to the state's own Nawegaon Nagzira Tiger Reserve (NNTR) for scientific population management. Brahmapuri, spread over around 2,900 sq. km including a 1,200 sq. km forested patch, is estimated to have 50 adult tigers and 25 sub-adults and cubs each, which is more than the numbers in several tiger projects. For instance, the NNTR has around eight tigers, while the 2018 census puts the base in the Sahyadri tiger reserve in the Western Ghats at just three.

Brahmapuri has a landscape fragmented by forests—around 350 of its 610 villages are near wooded areas, making it a powder keg for conflicts between humans and tigers, which often prey on cattle and attack people. These tigers, who disperse from the TATR, have also strayed into the abandoned coal mines around Chandrapur town and urban nodes like the Chandrapur Super Thermal Power Station (CSTPS), creating fresh conflict zones.

"Translocating tigers [from such congested landscapes] seems to be the only way out," says Mungantiwar, who belongs to Chandrapur, adding that they may have to shift 25 more tigers in addition to those who may be relocated from Bramhapuri to the NNTR under the scheme proposed presently. Shifting tigers from Brahmapuri to NNTR may bode well for the central Indian landscape as it has connectivity with tiger reserves like the TATR, Pench and Kanha and tiger-bearing areas like Balaghat in Madhya Pradesh. This will help in the dispersal of these animals and augment tiger numbers across the region. Despite spanning 1,894.94 sq. km across five protected areas in Bhandara and Gondia districts in Vidarbha, the NNTR habitat has a low density of resident and breeding tigers.

After that translocation goes through, the department plans to repopulate the Sahyadri reserve. For this, ungulates and herbivores will be released into these forests to develop a prey base for tigers. A senior forest official says they are taking measures like solar fencing of farmland to block straying wild animals, setting up chain-link fences on the periphery of villages and distributing LPG cylinders to deter villagers from venturing into the forests to collect firewood. Stall-feeding of cattle will also do away with the need for them to be taken into the forests for grazing. "Most human deaths occur due to people venturing into the forests rather than animals straying into human settlements," the official explains. Thermal fences with an early warning system will be set up in nine villages in the buffer of the TATR to provide real-time alerts about the presence of animals. Mungantiwar says that apart from translocating tigers from one natural habitat to another, they are also ready to loan their captive or semi-captive tigers to zoos in other states. The state forest department has around 19 tigers which have been captured in conflict situations or were found to have been maimed or injured and hence cannot be released into the wild.

THE MAHARASHTRA GOVT IS WORKING ON A PLAN TO TRANSLOCATE THE TEEMING TIGERS TO OTHER STATES AS WELL AS FROM CONGESTED AREAS TO ELSEWHERE WITHIN THE STATE

However, Bandu Dhotre, former wildlife warden of Chandrapur, and ex-member, Maharashtra State Board for Wildlife (MSBWL), says that while translocation will help reduce conflict in areas where tiger numbers have reached saturation point and help recover tiger populations in scantier parts, this is just a temporary solution.

"A conflict will arise when cubs and sub-adult tigers become adults and seek to establish their territory. Corridors from Chandrapur to other habitats must be strengthened to help them disperse to those areas. Linear projects like roads, canals and railway lines must have overpasses and underpasses to help these animals move... Translocation is only a temporary solution. We cannot keep on shifting large numbers of tigers every year," he adds.

Though translocation has helped recover tiger numbers in the Sariska (Rajasthan, 2008) and Panna (Madhya Pradesh, 2009) tiger reserves, the first inter-state tiger translocation project, launched in 2018, ended in failure. Two tigers, a male and a female, were relocated to the Satkosia tiger reserve, Odisha, from MP. While the male, Mahavir, was poached using metal snares in November 2018, the female, Sundari, was involved in conflict with humans. The suspension of that project offers a cautionary note to those who may be over-optimistic. ■